

CHAPTER 9 / ALCOHOL & OTHER DRUGS

You have probably heard the facts before - driving while impaired or intoxicated is a serious traffic safety problem in the United States. In New York State, more than 40 percent of all motor vehicle fatalities involve impaired driving. But the facts and statistics do not tell the whole story. Behind the numbers are thousands of lives cut short, permanent or disabling injuries, and families devastated because someone drove while under the influence of alcohol or other drugs.

When you drink alcohol or take other drugs, safe driving is not possible. Not every impaired or intoxicated driver causes a traffic crash, but each one is dangerous, putting their lives and those they share the road with at risk.

Young people, who have less experience with alcohol or drugs and less experience with driving, are at high risk. Drivers under age 21 are approximately 4 percent of the driving population, but 7 percent of the impaired drivers involved in fatal crashes. This is one reason the driver license revocation penalties are more severe for young drivers who drive under the influence of alcohol or other drugs.

Because driving “under the influence” is so dangerous, the penalties for alcohol or drug-related violations are tough and enforcement is important. The chance of apprehension and conviction are high and New York State law strictly limits your ability to plea bargain when charged with an offense related to alcohol or drugs.

WHAT ALCOHOL DOES

Alcohol delays your reaction time, reduces your ability to see clearly, changes your judgment of speed and distances, often makes you less inhibited and makes you more prone to take chances. The important skills you need to drive safely are made weaker.

Because your vision is normally restricted at night, it is especially dangerous to drink and drive after dark. Alcohol also reduces your ability to recover from the glare of headlights. When another

vehicle moves toward you, you can be blinded by its headlights for a long period of time.

You do not have to look or feel intoxicated for these things to occur. The effects of alcohol consumption can begin long before you become intoxicated or even legally impaired and begin with the first drink.

As alcohol physically limits your ability to drive, it also makes you less aware of what is happening to your safe driving abilities. It becomes difficult for you to judge your condition. You can gain confidence about driving, when you should not be driving at all.

During each mile you drive, you make hundreds of decisions. Your decisions turn into actions that keep your vehicle controlled and ensure you avoid crashes. Alcohol makes it difficult to make correct decisions and to take the safest actions.

For example: You have just stopped at a STOP sign. You see another vehicle approaching the intersection. You must quickly make a decision whether it is safe to go through the intersection. Under the influence of alcohol, you are more likely to make a wrong decision and “take a chance.” Your slower reaction time, and the bad decision, could cause a crash.

OTHER DRUGS

It can be a criminal offense to drive while impaired by the effect of drugs, alcohol or the combination of alcohol and drugs, including marijuana/cannabis, and illegal drugs such as, cocaine, LSD, heroin, opium and by some prescription drugs. Drugs can detrimentally affect your reflexes, judgment, vision and alertness and they may have other dangerous effects as well.

A combination of alcohol and other drugs severely reduces your ability to drive and can cause serious health problems, which can include death.

A combination of alcohol and other drugs severely reduces your ability to drive and can cause serious health problems, which can include death.